

Boom

Fifty-two nanoseconds after the explosion from the bomb vaporized Calvin Eckmann's flesh, his soul was expelled from the suspended wreckage of Pan-American Flight 67. It was invisible and essentially massless, encompassing the weight of only several million atoms, yet this puff of material held a photographic history of every sin and virtue in Calvin's regrettably short life. It floated into the sky, alongside the essences of two hundred eighty-five other innocent passengers, half a dozen stewardesses, the pilot, his co-pilot, and a debatably successful GRU operative. Industry jargon referred to all these people on the plane as the "payload."

Even sipping his gin & tonic from the leather seats in the Clipper Club, Calvin could tell it was gonna be a gorgeous day for flying – not a cloud in sight, and the summer air hung like warm, crisp towels fresh out of the laundromat. He'd stuck his cigarette in the divot of a crystal ashtray, and it smoldered delicately as he absentmindedly paged through *The Atlantic Monthly*.

The pilot had enacted a seatbelt advisory, he'd explained over the intercom in a crackling Southern drawl, because of minor turbulence from the local wind currents. A little blonde boy chased his sister back down the aisle toward their parents, shrieking with laughter at the vibrating floor. The plane would not arrive in Las Vegas in an hour as scheduled, and the FAA would find the pieces strewn across the southern Rocky Mountains after a day's search. The agency's administrator John H. Shaffer would find no evidence of commotion or struggle on the audio track from the Black Box, just a calmly chuckling pilot, then a sharp pop and static silence. Four months later, he would appear before Congress to testify about the safety of commercial aviation. In a few years, somebody would notice the merits of X-rays and other security devices now considered commonplace, but in those days airliner bombings weren't in vogue, and travel might as well have been governed by the honor system. As serendipity would have it, baggage handlers couldn't have placed the stolen Mk-54 Special Atomic Demolition Munition any closer to the DC-8-51's fuel tanks. Twisted iron and mangled hunks of charred human flesh flew in every direction, but there was no liquid blood, because the intense heat boiled it into a mist of ash. Somersaulting yellow cups dangled from rubber tubing, a reminder for passengers to secure their own oxygen masks before assisting others. Bits of flame-retardant stuffing spread like first snowfall from burst flotation cushions, tainted a sickly blue-green from the ruptured lavatory tanks. Melty wedding rings and blackened molar teeth provided the only identification for the poor Americans, whose final silhouettes remained, etched in seated tessellation by the force of ionizing radiation.

Fifty-two nanoseconds: exactly how long it took Calvin Eckmann's twenty-nine years of life to flash before his eyes. It might've been considerate to include extra days, months, seconds.

Because the flash was damn incomplete, unsatisfying, and anticlimactic. Only half his brain tissue survived the initial rapturous shockwave and blast, and his pineal gland didn't have much time to release all the N,N-Dimethyltryptamine necessary for a properly fantastic denouement. The disappointing montage arrived in bits and pieces, much as his life had concluded, and most of it wasn't worth remembering: The time Billy Johnson and he played hooky during P.E. class, sitting behind the old grocery store loading dock, sneaking a reefer while the employees were inside, hard at work; Jumping into a pile of leaves; Kicking apart fresh sandcastles as the supreme conqueror of the beach; triple-decker ice cream cones dripping a rainbow onto his clutched fist. But then there was that last weekend with Trudy, his sweetheart in Sacramento. She's probably going to have a lot of people comforting her, promising that Cal is looking down on her and their perfect, growing son. Neither of them is yet aware she is pregnant.

Unfortunately, he will be totally absent as a father or possible husband, for all Mr. Eckmann can currently see is a vivid whiteness. He remembers Trudy, but has already forgotten her face.

The bits of skeleton floating to Cal's right belonged to Alexi Andreyev, but none of his friends knew him by that name. A resident alien in the USA for nine years, he'd "fled" the Soviet Union and applied for political asylum as a defector. America was thrilled to oblige, and the man who'd stamped his forms looked him in the eyes, shook his hand, and with a proud grin, welcomed Andreyev "to the winning team." He'd spent his days outside Langley, poring over microfilms and pretending to be an anti-Pinko. Then one day the call came, and the generals explained it was time to prove his ultimate loyalty to his comrades by taking down an airliner.

A suicide mission wasn't in the job description. The GRU explained it wasn't Andreyev's fault, that a decade on enemy ground could corrupt even the best Soviets with the false and indulgent allures of Capitalism. They'd regretted to inform him that his mission, though so far successful, would be prematurely terminated for security concerns. They simply couldn't rule out the possibility he wasn't a double agent. His family would be spared, they solemnly promised, if he would have the courage to martyr himself in the service of the motherland. He purchased and utilized his ticket with Chechen identification cards, in the interest of shifting the blame to a marginal group of politically petulant and internationally unrecognized Caucasian hill people. The documentation had been looted from the actual dead bodies of insurgents back home. The Kremlin would pretend to be outraged, even retaliate against Grozny in a feigned show of solidarity with the Western dogs. It was akin to the tintinnabulous extermination of two Цыгане with one Kalashnikov.

The pieces have begun their initial descent. The plane was operating at a cruising altitude of 15,000 feet when the mechanical timer clicked on. Since the gusts and gales precluded any hopes for approaching terminal velocity, there was time yet for a show before the grand cataclysmic finale. Shredded metal rained from a tall dark cloud, and the once pure fuselage was stained a blackness of fresh octopus ink. The shards and hunks spun and danced, and a few loose feet took the opportunity to get footloose while the party was still good. The Black Box, dented but otherwise unscathed, hummed a silent siren song, a final low-frequency dirge that set the ball to a simple and clicking allegro 4/4 piece.

Those passengers unlucky enough to survive the initial inferno? Their screams formed a chorus of melancholic melody, somewhat of a round between a few dozen people pleading for Jesus to save them, Oh God, please save them please. The wind at this altitude drowned out their cries, reducing them to manic blathering chatter. Though these people are still more or less fully intact, the landing will not leave pretty marks on their bodies, and they shall receive the same closed-casket burials as the cremated passengers. A single dove flies by as the wreckage plummets like grains of peppercorn from a cosmic grinder. He takes a second glance, but that's all time affords him before a 17,000 pound Pratt & Whitney turbofan knocks him from the sky.

Calvin Eckmann's horn-rimmed eyeglasses, spider-cracked on the left lens, are also falling. They will land amongst a myriad of tragic memorabilia, forming many of the TV news photobites as the confused and terrified national community mourns the loss of three hundred or so compatriots. They will see men in white suits with Geiger counters sifting through the dirt, pulling up the occasional intact wallet, earring, and – once – what appears to be a puddled Mr. Potato Head. The glasses twirl like seeds from a maple tree, spinning faster than they tumble. The breeze is aiding this ballet. The sun catches the good lens, and for two-thirds of a second, a vibrant rainbow shimmers across the glass as if to offer a redemptive apology. The prism is tinted red from a fine mist of Eckmann's bodily fluids, which were violently jettisoned from their natural compartments, and burned dry onto the glass. The winged gold nametag of stewardess

Marsha Thomas, still clasped shut, glides and twists in the wind, clinging a shred of tattered blue uniform that flaps like a tiny flag.

As the souls continue outward into the void of space, the pale in Cal's eyesight fades, and he is able to gaze upon a globe with no borders or barriers, where things are either land or sea. He sees America and the USSR, but cannot make out their boundaries or geography. While he's pretty sure he can tell them apart, he's surprised at how homogenous everything looks from space. The two nations appear identical. Peaceful, even. No explosions or famine or torture or winter cold to cause the same misery, inflicted on humanity again and again. Then, the poor travelers surpassed the atmosphere, and the only homes they knew dissolved into a smudge.

Three hundred and fifty-five seconds after the in-flight demolition of Pan-American Flight 67, twisted steel plows into the dirt on a mountain slope in northeast Nevada. A massive and filthy plume of brown dust erupts as the pieces bored into the earth and entomb themselves. Straggling bits catch up as the clouds blow past, thudding intermittently with the pit-pat of an April shower. A mountaineer stares at a dark puffball that mars the pure azure horizon, believing it to be a UFO. She phones the police and says they better get up here cause it's either aliens or those Reds.

In spite of their vastly different beliefs and lives, Andreyev the Slav atheist and Eckmann the American Jew have identical ethereal destinies. Their paths do not deviate, and even the meanest men and worst women aboard the aircraft do not stray Earthward towards the fire. Perhaps it was fate that they died together, that their lives culminated in this brilliant orgasmic flash of light and heat. Andreyev thinks of his younger brother Vanya, who is still working on the family farm in Chelyabinsk Oblast, and his mother Olga, who made terrific lingonberry jam. The pilot learned in aeronautics school that he didn't have the aptitude or calculus skills to be an astronaut, but now he figures Neil Armstrong had another one coming if he thought he'd be the last guy to walk on the moon anytime soon. In Washington, a red phone rang. It was August 1, 1970, but as far as the Heavens were concerned, today could've been any other day. People burned brightly in life, but every single one would fade into dissipate nothingness like so many twinkling stars, and it was happening all the time.